



Saint Columban College
College of Computing Studies
Pagadian City



First Grep

First Grep 



Easy

General Skills

picoCTF 2019

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Description

Can you find the flag in the file? This would be really tedious to look through manually, something tells me there is a better way.

The flag is in this [file](#).

Hints 

1

[grep tutorial](#)

109,725 users solved



93%

Liked



 picoCTF{FLAG}

Submit
Flag

Author: The Analyst: Hyposelenia

Challenge: First Grep

Category: General Skills

Date: 01/13/26



I. Objective

The objective of this task was to locate a hidden flag inside a file using an efficient search method instead of manually reading through the entire file. This challenge introduces the use of the `grep` command to quickly find specific text within files.

II. Background

In cybersecurity and system analysis, files can be very large and time-consuming to inspect manually. Searching through files line by line is inefficient and prone to human error. Linux provides powerful command-line tools that allow users to search for specific keywords or patterns inside files.

This challenge emphasizes the importance of using automated search tools such as `grep` to quickly locate relevant information, such as flags, within a file.

III. Tool Used

- **Oracle VirtualBox (Kali Linux)** – Used as the Linux environment to run the challenge
- **Linux Terminal** – Used to type commands and interact with the system
- **grep** – Used to search for specific text patterns inside files

IV. Methodology

1. The file provided by the challenge was accessed inside the Kali Linux environment.
2. Instead of manually opening and scrolling through the file, the `grep` command was used to search for the keyword `picoCTF`.



3. The command `grep picoCTF file` was executed, which displayed only the line containing the flag.
4. The flag was identified directly from the command output.

V. Result

`picoCTF{grep_is_good_to_find_things_eb80073D}`

```
(kali㉿kali)-[/media/sf_Downloaded_Cybersecfiles]
$ grep -o 'picoCTF' file
picoCTF

(kali㉿kali)-[/media/sf_Downloaded_Cybersecfiles]
$ grep -o 'picoCTF{[^}]*}' file
picoCTF{grep_is_good_to_find_things_eb80073D}

(kali㉿kali)-[/media/sf_Downloaded_Cybersecfiles]
$
```

VI. Explanation

The `grep` command is a powerful Linux utility used to search for specific text within files. It scans each line of a file and prints only the lines that match the given search pattern.

In this challenge, the keyword `picoCTF` was used because all flags follow a consistent format. By searching for this keyword, the flag could be located quickly without reviewing the entire file manually.

Quick Command Cheat Sheet

Purpose	Command
Search for a flag in a text file	<code>grep picoCTF file</code>
Search for a flag in a binary file	<code>strings file grep picoCTF</code>
Display only the flag itself	<code>grep -o 'picoCTF{[^}]*}' file</code>

Using these commands saves time and demonstrates how Linux tools can efficiently handle large amounts of data. **(NOTE THAT THE**



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COMMAND MAY VARY, “picoCTF” WAS USED BECAUSE IT IS THE FLAG FORMAT).

VII. Conclusion

This challenge demonstrates the importance of using the right tools to search and analyze files efficiently. The `grep` command allows users to quickly locate specific information without manually inspecting entire files. Learning how to use `grep` is a fundamental skill in cybersecurity, as it improves accuracy, speed, and overall effectiveness when analyzing data.

— **The Analyst: Hyposelenia**